National
Qualifications
2026

2026 ESOL

Listening

Higher

Question Paper Finalised Marking Instructions

These marking instructions have been prepared by examination teams for use by Qualifications Scotland appointed markers when marking external course assessments.

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General marking principles for Higher ESOL Listening

Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.

(a) Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.

(b) If a candidate response does not seem to be covered by either the principles or detailed marking instructions, and you are uncertain how to assess it, you must seek guidance from your team leader.

(c) Use your professional judgement, subject knowledge and experience, and understanding to award marks to candidate responses.

(d) The marking instructions indicate the essential idea that a candidate should provide for each answer and there may be variation in candidate responses. Award marks according to the accuracy and relevance of a candidate's answers.

(e) The answers for each question must come from the original recording. Award marks where the candidate's answer is accurate and expressed in their own words.

(f) Where questions require a response of, for example 'no more than three words', do not penalise candidates if they use an additional word, provided that the essential idea required by the question is correct.

(g) Do not penalise candidates for spelling mistakes where they have clearly understood the meaning of the word.

(h) Where there is a multiple choice question and the candidate ticks more boxes than required: award **0 marks** where a candidate ticks all boxes. If two answers are required and the candidate ticks three boxes with two correct answers, award **1 mark**. If two answers are required and a candidate ticks three boxes with one correct answer, award **0 marks**.

(i) For overall purpose questions, candidates must draw meaning from their overall understanding of the recording.

Marking instructions for each question

Recording 1

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
1.			under the radar	**1**	No more than 3 words (NMT3W)
2.			to break (through)	**1**	NMT3W Needs 'to' Accept 'brake'
3.			(massive) data breaches/credit card thefts/leaked data/cybercrimes/ digital breaches	**1**	NMT3W ACCEPT 'stolen data'/'information (being) leaked'/'credit card leak'/ leaking personal information. DO NOT ACCEPT 'personal leaks'
4.			processing/transaction fees	**1**	NMT3W Needs both words
5.			moving forward	**1**	NMT3W Needs both words
6.			C	**1**	
7.			A E G	**3**	

Recording 2

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
8.			D	**1**	
9.			C	**1**	
10.			C	**1**	
11.			cabin crew	**1**	No more than 2 words DO NOT ACCEPT 'captain crew'
12.			(on-site) nursery	**1**	NMT2W DO NOT ACCEPT childcare /'nerserny'
13.			source	**1**	NMT2W ACCEPT 'find'/'sort'. DO NOT ACCEPT 'provide'/'help with'/'fund'/'search'
14.			(glowing) reference	**1**	NMT2W
15.			D	**1**	

Recording 3

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
16.			memories of exams	**1**	No more than 3 words DO NOT ACCEPT 'memories' only
17.			(professions like) nursing	**1**	NMT3W DO NOT ACCEPT 'a profession'
18.			projected earnings/ earnings of graduates	**1**	NMT3W DO NOT ACCEPT 'earnings' only. Needs earning idea AND projection/ graduate idea.
19.			transferring (their) anxiety	**1**	NMT3W ACCEPT 'transferring our anxiety'
20.			A	**1**	
21.			D	**1**	
22.			D	**1**	
23.			A	**1**	

[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]